

CROWD PULLER
Jaya Kishori in Mhow

PREACHERS ARE DELIVERING SERMONS AT THE INVITATION OF THEIR POLITICAL HOSTS ACROSS MP

Congress leader Mitendra Darshan Singh. While Jaya avoids controversial or overtly political statements, her ability to draw crowds makes her one of the most sought-after.

There are others who are in great demand. Avdheshanand Giri, who was known earlier for his proximity to Congress leader Ajay Singh and is now close to Chouhan, is being regularly signed up, as is Devkinandan Thakur. BJP ticket hopeful from Bhopal South West, Rahul Kothari, organised a discourse by Thakur in April. Rawatpur Sarkar, a Bhind-based preacher, who has a sprawling empire of educational institutions, is also politically aligned. He does not see eye to eye with Govind Singh who has been winning despite his opposition. Another godman from the region is Pandokhar Maharaj who is considered close to home minister Narottam Mishra.

Do these preachers customise their sermons as per their hosts' needs? While Shastri and Mishra are known to invoke the 'Hindu rashtra' demand quite often, Shastri refrained from making such comments at Chhindwara. "Religious symbolism has been part of politics for a long time. Be it Mahatma Gandhi, Tilak or even Muslim League leaders in the past, they were identified with religion besides politics," says veteran journalist N.K. Singh, "The modern-day *kathavachaks* command a huge following but the extent to which they can influence voting is not known."

The engagement of preachers like Shastri in political contexts sparks debates. Shastri's comment that the Gyanvapi Mosque is a temple has drawn criticism from some Congress leaders who have questioned the propriety of aligning with such a figure. Nath has defended his decision to invite Shastri to Chhindwara, where, in a deft move, an all-religion prayer meet was also organised along with Shastri's religious discourse. "Dhirendra Shastri did not talk of a Hindu rashtra in Chhindwara, he spoke of all religions. Eighty-two per cent of the population in India is Hindu. The numbers speak for themselves. There is no need for a controversy around Hindu rashtra," said Nath, downplaying the issue.

Kathas are expensive affairs. Organisers have to foot the bills for tents, *bhandara* (food), and transport and accommodation for the godmen and their whole entourage. Some preachers charge fees for their sermons, while others don't mind donations. Shastri asserts that he doesn't charge for his sermons, but organisers cover event expenses. "The total cost of holding a programme is between Rs 1 crore and Rs 2 crore, depending on the duration it is held for," a politician who recently organised a *katha* told INDIA TODAY.

Though the impact of these collaborations on election outcomes remains a subject of speculation, the role of godmen as conduits between faith and politics continues to evolve in MP. ■

RAJASTHAN

GEHLOT'S OBC GOOGLY

By Rohit Parihar

Caste and politics make for inseparable bedfellows, and it never gets more conspicuous than when elections are around the corner. In Rajasthan, where not one but two electoral battles await the ruling Congress—the assembly polls later this year and the general elections in mid-2024—Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot set the ball rolling by announcing a caste census and a six per cent additional reservation for the state's "original" Other Backward Class (OBC) communities.

On August 9, with former Congress president Rahul Gandhi by



"WE WANT TO BEGIN A CASTE CENSUS IN RAJASTHAN.... PEOPLE SHOULD GET THEIR SHARE BASED ON THEIR CASTE STRENGTH"

ASHOK GEHLOT
Chief Minister, Rajasthan